OPENCLASSROOMS

LOCALIZATION
FRENCH LANGUAGE
STYLE GUIDE

OPENCLASSROOMS

making education accessible

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1. Company Overview and Values

OpenClassrooms is a mission-driven company with the ambition to make education accessible to everyone, everywhere. We are the leading online education platform in Europe and Africa, offering fully accredited online diplomas based on the skills of the future. Each month, 300 000 free students from around the world connect to our platform, and we currently count 12 000 persons among our degree students. As such, we are now the leading online school in Europe and Africa and offer 100% online diplomas recognized by the State.

2. OpenClassrooms' Tone of Voice and Linguistic Style

2.1. Tone of Voice:

The OpenClassrooms' voice is **casual**, **straightforward**, and most importantly, **accessible**.

OpenClassrooms' learning products aim for a friendly, informal style and conversational tone. In translation, and even if French tends to naturally be more formal that English, our voice remains **warm, friendly and casual**, yet **knowledgeable, concise** and to the point. We want students to feel comfortable with the learning material, so it is essential that our message feels personal and close.

It can be best summed up as:

> *"Imagine one of your friends comes over, you have a cup of coffee, and then they show you how to code in Java/improve your Excel skills/speak better in public/etc."*

Emojis, jokes, and references are more than welcome!

We encourage translators to take reasonable liberties with the source material they are translating to align with this style/tone. Furthermore, depending on the topic/field of the course, you may want to adjust the tone to being more or less casual.

Please aim for a style focused on accessibility, i.e. short sentences with simple structure, common/non-academic vocabulary, focusing on precision and directness.

2.1. Best Practices

Here are few general things to keep in mind:

- Always use formal “vous” when addressing students.
- Use short sentences. They have more impact and read faster.
- Be succinct.
- Always keep the final French-speaking student in mind. While terminology is key, stay away from overcomplicated jargon and adapt cultural references whenever you deem it necessary.
- Limit the use of abbreviations and acronyms.
- Keep a tone of voice similar to the one in the source language.

3. Language Reference

Should you have any doubt, the reference dictionary is **Larousse**.

Other useful sources:

Grammar and spelling	Terminology	Lexicology
• **Académie française** • **Reverso** • **Cordial**	• Microsoft Language Portal is particularly helpful for UI terms • Termium • E-commerce Glossary	• Dictionnaire des synonymes CRISCO • Dictionnaire des collocations

4. Terminology and Consistency

Please always follow the glossary provided with each project and pay special attention to those terms related to OpenClassrooms’ brand identity and course structure , as it is crucial that these are **translated consistently at all times.**

Examples:

English	French	Note
Let’s Recap	**En résumé**	*Sub-section of a chapter*
Get the most out of this course	**Tirez un maximum de ce cours**	*Section that introduces a course*

Learning outcome	Objectif pédagogique	
Path	**parcours**	
Skill	**compétence**	
Prerequisite	**prérequis**	
Projet Presentation	**soutenance**	

These are just a few examples. The full version of the termbase is available on XTM.

If you have any doubts about French content, please get in touch with the OpenClassrooms' Content Localization Specialist managing the project. If you think a term should be added to the glossary, you can add your suggestion in the dedicated tab of the Localization Handoff.

5. Language and Grammar

5.1. Spelling

There is usually only one way to spell words in French, with very few exceptions. Generally, any spelling found in a reliable modern French dictionary is acceptable.

5.2. Verbs

In accordance with OpenClassrooms' pedagogical philosophy, all learning product titles (as well as part, chapter, and section titles) as well as learning outcomes (the bullet points that are preceded by "By the end of this course/training, etc., you will be able to:" should start with an action verb in the imperative:
Example:

Do	Don't
Chapitre 1 - Découvrez l'importance de l'esprit d'équipe en gestion de projet agile	Chapitre 1 - L'esprit d'équipe en gestion de projet agile
Chapitre 3 - Administrez des formulaires de façon sécurisée	Chapitre 3 - Comment administrer des formulaires de façon sécurisée

5.3. Grammatical gender and inclusive language

Please be aware of gender agreement within the text, when addressing a student. Whenever possible, try to use a neutral structure and be extra careful using templates where you need to add specific names or details, but the rest of the text is recycled.

When gender neutrality is not possible, the masculine forms will be used. As a general rule, we need a balance, so please keep inclusive language in mind and apply neutral forms when possible, but our main goal is to produce user-friendly localised content, with accuracy and clarity as our top priorities.

5.4. Capitalization

Note that in English texts, capitals are often used in a different way in titles or headlines. You may find that every word is capitalized in headlines, banner texts and other elements.

French does not follow this distinction. Always apply the French spelling rules and do not follow the capitalization used in the source text.

- Common capitalisation rules in French: first letter of the first word in a sentence and proper nouns.
- The first letter of each word in the full (expanded) term for an acronym.
- Trademarks in English.
- Brand and product names.
- However, days and months such as *Monday* and *January* are not capitalised e.g. lundi, janvier, etc.

Please avoid following the English capitalization *systematically*.

5.5. Active VS. Passive Voice

Try using the active voice whenever possible, as the passive voice is usually lengthier.

Do	Don't
En fonction de la structure organisationnelle de votre entreprise,	En fonction de la structure organisationnelle de votre entreprise,

nous observerons différents types de de management.	différents types de de management **pourront être observés**.

5.6. Punctuation

a. Non-breaking spaces

Non-breaking spaces are required:

- **Between numbers and nouns, abbreviations, currencies, symbols, etc.**

Examples
3 caractères 10 km 2e étage 17,85 € (monetary value) 50 % (percentage) 10 h 30 (time)

- Before colons (:), semicolons (;), exclamation marks (!) and question marks (?)
- After opening quotation marks and before closing quotation marks. e.g.: « chevrons ».
- Between day and month, and between month and year. e.g.: 14 septembre 2009
- To insert a thousand separator. e.g. 5 425

b. Standard spaces

A space should be inserted after full stops (.), commas (,), three points (...), exclamation marks (!), question marks (?), colons (:) and semicolons (;).

c. Italics and bold for punctuation

When words in italics or in bold are followed by punctuation, the punctuation should also be in italics or in bold.

5.7. Anglicisms

Depending on the topic of the course, you may encounter many terms that may need to stay in English in the French translation. As those are often standard because they are used in a given industry, you do not need to put them in italics or in quotation marks. When you are unsure whether to keep the English term or to use a translated version, always make sure to check the term base and to search the Internet to identify the most common version used in real-life situations / the industry.

5.8. Emojis

Emojis are commonly used in OpenClassrooms' courses.

- Emojis that appear in source text should be kept in the target language, unless it is irrelevant.
- Emojis should be be inserted after punctuation, not before :

Do	Don't
Bien joué ! Vous avez terminé la première partie. 🎉 Maintenant, [...]	Bien joué ! Vous avez terminé la première partie 🎉. Maintenant, [...]

6. Formatting and Layout

6.1. Quotation marks

Please use straight English style quotation marks, as opposed to the French *chevrons* (« ») Note: while we are aware that it would be better to follow the French punctuation rules and use the appropriate quotation marks, our Content Management System does not currently let us insert nonbreaking spaces, which are recommended, if not required, when using the standard French *chevrons*.

<u>Example:</u>

Do	Don't
Pour simplifier, ce que l'on appelle "structure organisationnelle", c'est un	Pour simplifier, ce que l'on appelle « structure organisationnelle », c'est un

organigramme qui explique comment votre entreprise fonctionne.	organigramme qui explique comment votre entreprise fonctionne.

6.2. Bulleted lists

- When the list contains items as complete sentences, each item begins with an upper-case letter and ends with a full stop, for example:

  Les chats présentent certaines caractéristiques :
  - *Ils dorment plusieurs heures par jour.*
  - *Ils apprécient la chaleur du soleil.*
  - *Ils ronronnent quand ils sont contents.*

- When the list contains items that run on from an introductory clause, each item begins with a lower-case letter and ends with a semicolon, except the last item, which ends with a full stop, for example:

  Les chats sont connus pour :
  - *leurs nombreuses siestes ;*
  - *leur amour de la chaleur du soleil ;*
  - *leurs ronronnements qui marquent leur contentement.*

- When the list contains short items (nouns or noun phrases), no punctuation is required. General capitalization rules apply, for example:

  On associe les chats aux concepts suivants :
  - *La sieste*
  - *Le prélassement au soleil*
  - *Le ronronnement*

6.3. Slashes (/)

Slashes are used to indicate alternatives or to express a prepositional value. Slashes are not too common in French, and they tend to be fall under the following categories:

- To substitute a preposition placed between 2 items. Example: 50 €/heure
- To indicate alternatives. Example: Paiement par carte de débit/crédit.
- To separate the different items within a date. Example: 15/08/2022

Non-breaking spaces are used before and after a slash, if the alternative consists of more than one word. If there is only one word on each side, spaces should not be used.

6.4. Dates

There are different correct formats to provide dates in French, but we'll stick to the following for consistency reasons.

- **Standard date format**. The standard format used for dates is day-month-year.
  Example: 8 décembre 1976.

  If space is limited the form dd/mm/yy can be used. Days and months can be written with or without a leading zero for numbers below ten (6/5/2019 or 06/05/2019), but zeros are more and more common. Years should be written with two or four numbers (09 or 2009).

- **Abbreviations for days and months** have three or four letters (when possible):
  - Days: lun., mar., mer., jeu., ven., sam., dim.
  - Months: janv., févr., mars, avr., mai, juin, juil., août, sept., oct., nov., déc.

6.5. Time

Please use the **24-hour time format**.

A **leading zero** can be used for hours, but is not necessary. For minutes and seconds, a leading zero is obligatory, e.g.: 09 h 05 or 9 h 05. Please use a lowercase "h" as hour/minute separator, with a non-breaking space before and after it, e.g.: "De 10 h 00 à 23 h 30".

Do	Don't
08 h 20 21 h 30 13 h 15	8:20 am 9:30 pm 13h15m

Generally speaking, translators are recommended to: - write "minute(s)" and "heure(s) in full when it expresses lengths of time. - use the abbreviation for when talking about specific times e.g. "Heure de début : 08 h 30"

6.6. Currencies

When localizing courses in French, the local currency symbol used should always be **€** and it should always go after the number, with a non-breaking space. Please avoid using a 3-letter currency code:

Do	Don't
30 €	30 EUR 30€ €30 € 30
30,50 €	30,5 €

IMPORTANT NOTE:

Rates indicated in foreign currencies mustn't be converted when they are part of a course, an exercise or a scenario. You can simply keep the source amount and replace the currency symbol with a euro sign.

Example: **$500** will become **500 €**.
Please raise a query if there is any doubt which currency should be used.

6.7. Units of measurement

- **Weight:** In general, please only use grams (g) and kilos (kg).
- **Distances:** Please convert measurements and use the metric system only. As a general rule, please use the abbreviation for kilometres (km), metes (m) and centimetres (cm) in lists of locations or itineraries.
- **Surface area:** Regarding square metres, please use the abbreviation: **m²** (ALT 0178). Imperial units of measurement should be converted into the metric system in most cases, but not always (see specific project instructions).

Conversion table	
1 mile	1,6 kilometres (km)

1 yard	0,9144 metres (m)
1 foot	30,48 centimetres (cm)
1 inch	2,54 centimetres (cm)
1 acre	0,4047 hectare
1 square foot	0,0929 square metres (m^2)

Please round up distances and surface areas in order to limit the number to 2 decimals.

6.8. Numbers

Please spell out numbers below 10 and use numerals for 10 and above, unless the number precedes a unit of measure or is used as input. Numbers with decimals are written in numerals.

- **Decimals**
  A comma is always used in French as a decimal separator.
- **Thousands**
  A non-breaking space is always used in French as a thousand separator.
- **Percentages**
  A non-breaking space is required before the percentage symbol.

6.9. Acronyms and abbreviations

Acronyms
English acronyms are often trademarks or well-known organisations, and they should remain as they appear in the English source, unless a commonly known equivalent exists in French.
As a general rule, spell the acronym out on first use with the abbreviation in parentheses. If needed, specify this is an English acronym. Then use the acronym throughout the rest of the content.

Symbols and abbreviations
Symbols and abbreviations can be used in specific contexts for layout reasons when space is limited and characters limits apply.

<u>Examples:</u>

Abbreviation	
premier, première	1er, 1ère
centimètre	cm
et cetera	, etc.
par exemple	p. ex
heure	h
mètre carré	m^2
code postal	C.P.
numéro	n°
Reportez-vous à	cf.

Please translate these symbols as follows:

& = et
# = n°

6.10. Telephone numbers

Telephone numbers do not use hyphens, they should be separated using a non-breaking space and they should be arranged as follows:

- **Landline:** (International code) + Rest of the numbers arranged in pairs
- **Mobile:** (International code) + Rest of the numbers arranged in pairs

Examples:

Landline	Mobile
91 529 82 10	606 37 30 58
+33 (0)5 49 78 41 50	+33 (0)6 09 37 30 58

6.11. Addresses

Please note the format for a postal address in French is considerably different from the US or the UK.

Addressee name
Street, Number, Flat, Door
Postcode City
Province (optional)
Country (optional)

Examples:

Jean Bonbeurre
10 rue de la Baguette qui croustille
75019 Paris
France

7. URLs Localization

8. Cultural Adaptation

OpenClassrooms are designed to be as relevant as possible for students. When localizing English courses into French, you will often encounter examples, scenarii or exercises that may need to be localized to make sense for French-speaking students.

We encourage you to adapt the content the best you can, and to get in touch with your Content Localization Specialist if you are not sure how to proceed, or if you need a second opinion

7.1. Places

7.2. Fictitious companies

7.3. Fictitious characters

7.2. Cultural references

- Films, songs, books

7.3. Jokes

Last updated by Florian on Nov. 23, 2022